IV. NACHRUF

Calvert Watkins (*13.03.1933 – † 20.03.2013)

Much has already been written about the life and achievements of Calvert Watkins, following his death at the age of eighty in March of 2013.[1] Yet for such a towering figure, who touched the lives of so many, there is always more to say. These brief remarks, which I am honored to have been asked to contribute, expand in a personal way on the topic of Calvert Watkins as teacher.

In the fall semester of 1971, in the beginning of my third undergraduate year at Harvard, I enrolled in Calvert Watkins's course Classical Philology 236, "Seminar in Latin Historical Grammar". This was a course normally restricted to graduate students, but I had earned this privilege because of my having taken, the previous spring, the prerequisite course Classical Philology 234 ("Historical and Comparative Grammar of Latin"), taught by Gregory Nagy, with the Latin portions of Meillet-Vendryes 1948 as the required textbook. The general direction of my future studies was already becoming clear to me; but the first meeting of Professor Watkins's seminar sealed my fate. My folder of notes for that course contains 65 pages of furiously-scribbled material, which I struggled to take down – and take in – during each lecture. The first line of the first page reads as follows: "in 2nd conj.: *-*ē*-; so-called 'statives' – read about origin of 2nd conj. statives". Further down the page occurs the notation "also: the denom. (secondary) suffix – *senēre* < *sen(ex)*, *albēre* 'to be *albus*', etc.", followed by the question "are these 2 the same *-*ē*-?". Many readers of this journal will not need to be told that the students in that classroom in Cambridge, Massachusetts were "present at the creation", so to speak, of Watkins's celebrated paper on the denominative statives (1973a). The lectures on this topic filled three more meetings, for a total of twelve hours and 28 pages of my notes, the margins overflowing with verb forms from Hittite – a language I had not yet studied, but which somehow (even I was able to see) held the key to the solution of this fas-

1 See the eloquent and thorough treatment by Melchert (2013:506–12), with a complete list of publications (2013:512–26), as well as the more informal testimonies gathered in Jamison, Melchert and Vine 2014.

cinating problem. But there was much more to come: many more sessions, each one beginning with a problem in Latin phonology or morphology, but inevitably requiring me to record page upon page of forms in a seemingly endless stream of ancient Indo-European languages (what undergraduate had ever heard of Tocharian or Palaic?), including ancient Italic ones with exotic names like Marsian and Paelignian. In retrospect, I eventually became aware that much of this material made its way into other publications of about the same vintage, sometimes packaged in a single article (such as Watkins 1973b), but often integrated into works devoted mainly to other topics.

It is difficult to convey the excitement generated by the experience of observing this young and dynamic professor in action, deploying form after form on the blackboard in the service of rigorously argued attacks on serious linguistic problems, leading eventually to solutions that even a relatively uninformed undergraduate could see were nothing short of brilliant. Roman Jakobson, one of Watkins's own teachers, is said to have asserted that the experience of reading a good linguistic article should be like attending a fine dinner to which you have been invited, and that you do not need to be dragged through the kitchen. Indeed, Watkins's published articles are like those fine dinners; but his teaching was not! In his seminars, even those directly related to eventual publications, we found ourselves in a very hot kitchen: inspecting the ingredients, tasting the broth, and in general getting our hands dirty. Watkins realized that only in this way could we actually learn how to do this sort of thing ourselves.

Nor was it just a barrage of linguistic forms – far from it! The instruction I recorded at the very beginning of my notes ("read about origin of 2nd conj. statives") was the first of many such explicit directives, often accompanied with references to secondary literature. Prominent, of course, were authors who wrote on Latin and Italic topics (my notes contain references both to standard handbooks by Leumann, Sommer, Devoto, Neue-Wagener, and others, and also to quite recent works like Mignot 1969); but just as frequent were references to Benveniste, Brugmann, Chantraine, Kuryłowicz, Meillet, Wackernagel, and many others. And the texts! In connection with those linguistic forms, whole passages would appear on the blackboard, not just from familiar authors like Plautus, Lucretius, and Cicero, and (to an undergraduate Classics major) only vaguely familiar authors like Ennius, Livius Andronicus, Naevius, Pacuvius, Accius, or Aulus Gellius, but also Latin inscriptional material, texts in Oscan, Umbrian and other Italic languages, passages from the Rig-Veda and from something called "the Anitta text", fragments of Old Irish poetry, and

glosses from Festus and Hesychius.[2] How could anyone experience this much intellectual richness, this analytical virtuosity, and not conceive a desire to emulate it?

Eventually, however, the time came to produce the sole graded exercise for the course: a "term paper" – the first I had ever attempted on a linguistic topic – in which I would have to research a problem in Latin historical and comparative grammar. The prospect filled me with dread, and for good reason: as an undergraduate Classics major, I was a little better off than Shakespeare, with his "small Latine and lesse Greeke",[3] and I could read French. But all the rest – Vedic Sanskrit, Hittite, Tocharian, Old Irish, even German – was just a dream that seemed impossible of attainment. I needn't have feared: Professor Watkins was immensely supportive, and steered me toward a topic that seemed as if it might be manageable for a raw beginner, namely the background of the small set of Latin adverbs in *-am* (*clam*, *cōram*, *palam*, etc.). In the end, of course, I produced nothing of any value whatsoever, mainly regurgitating, and doing my best to weigh, various handbook theories about these forms, insofar as I could understand them. I fully expected a failing grade, which I would have richly deserved, at least in comparison to the work that must have been produced by the seasoned graduate students in the course. Indeed, when the paper was returned, I leafed through the pages with horror: they bristled with corrections and marginal comments, and even the bibliography was voluminously marked up, with corrections entered on almost every entry. Yet miraculously, at the bottom of the last page, I saw the letter "A". Of course I realized, at some level, that the grade itself was an act of charity, designed to provide encouragement in the face of the devastating critiques so clearly visible in the marginalia. It had the desired effect, as did the marginalia themselves: Watkins cared enough about his students to provide them with firm and explicit criticism. The next time, we would not make the same mistakes – at least in the preparation of the bibliography.

It was impossible to study with Calvert Watkins without becoming aware of his own veneration of his teachers, and not just the mentors in his immediate past, as in the simple but eloquent dedication of what we then called "the Blue Book" (Watkins 1969).[4] He saw himself, with full justice, as a member of a long line of Indo-Europeanists going back to the neo-grammarians themselves. Nor was there the

2 I think it must have been in this seminar that Watkins dispensed his recommendation that we should obtain a copy of Festus and put it on our nightstands for bedside reading. This pronouncement would have been delivered with a sly smile and a twinkle in the eye; eventually, I would realize that the advice (like many other such gems) was meant only half-jokingly.

3 Ben Jonson, "To the Memory of My Beloved the Author, William Shakespeare" (1623).

4 "Meinen Lehrern: E. BENVENISTE, D. A. BINCHY, R. JAKOBSON, J. KURYŁOWICZ".

slightest conceitedness or egotism about this: it was simple fact, something like a religious calling, having to do with what one learned from one's teachers, and from the teachers of one's teachers, and so on, all the way back to Saussure himself. For those of us who had the good fortune to be taught by Calvert Watkins, the sense of feeling as if we belonged to this great tradition – something he took pains to inculcate in his teaching even to those of us unworthy to be a part of it – was surely one of the most fulfilling experiences of our lives. This portion of his life's work deserves to be commemorated, alongside his remarkable (and perhaps better-known) achievements as a historical linguist.

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